

DIGITAL ADDICTION AND ITS IMPACT ON YOUTH MENTAL HEALTH

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Review of literature

In today's technologically driven society, the relationship between individuals and digital media has become increasingly complex. The paper "The Biopsychosocial Impact of Abusive Use of Digital Media" sheds light on the significant issue of Internet addiction (IA), which affects a notable portion of the population. Research indicates that the prevalence of IA ranges from 5% to nearly 38%, highlighting its status as a serious public health concern in various countries . Despite its widespread impact, IA (Internet addiction) is not yet formally recognized in major diagnostic manuals such as the DSM-V or ICD-11, which complicates the development of effective treatment strategies The findings of the paper reveal a concerning relationship between Internet addiction and various psychiatric comorbidities, including depression, anxiety, and sleep disorders. This duality raises critical questions about whether IA leads to these mental health issues or if pre-existing conditions contribute to the development of IA . Furthermore, the paper emphasises the extensive biopsychosocial consequences of excessive digital media use, affecting individuals' work, study, personal relationships, and parenting.

(The Biopsychosocial Impact of Abusive Use of Digital Media

Gabriella Di Girolamo Martins,+8 more)

In Bhavnagar, India, the study focused on the issue of problematic Internet use (PIU) among school-going adolescents.

Bhavnagar, like many other places, has seen a significant increase in Internet accessibility among adolescents. This rise in usage has led to concerns about how young people manage their online activities and the potential for developing problematic behaviours related to Internet use . Many adolescents in Bhavnagar struggle to control their Internet usage, which can result in distress and impair their daily functioning. This situation is particularly alarming given the

developmental stage of adolescents, who are more susceptible to the negative impacts of excessive Internet use. The findings from Bhavnagar indicate that problematic Internet use can lead to various negative outcomes, including academic decline and mental health issues. This emphasises the need for awareness and preventive measures to support adolescents in managing their Internet use responsibly .

Predictors of problematic Internet use in school going adolescents of Bhavnagar, India.
(Sneha Vadher,+6 more , 11 Feb 2019, International Journal of Social Psychiatry)

Introduction of the problem statement: Digital Addiction and its impact on youth mental health

Digital addiction, often referred to as a "silent killer," has significantly altered the neurobiology and daily lives of many young people in India. This growing phenomenon encompasses excessive dependence on digital devices, platforms, and content such as social media, gaming, and even pornography. The problem is not just about screen time; it is about how deeply these platforms have woven themselves into the emotional and mental fabric of the younger generation. From the words we use to the opinions we form, the content we consume daily dictates everything. *Digitalisation, which once promised to revolutionise India for the better, has, in many ways, turned into a digital nightmare.*

Information fatigue, the shortening attention span of the masses and behavioural changes due to constant content consumption are at the forefront of this nightmare.

The very devices that were meant to connect and empower us are now key contributors to heightened levels of stress and anxiety.

Increased rates of anxiety and stress among young children have been linked to their early exposure to smartphones and social media. Children as young as five or six are being handed devices that allow them unlimited access to content.

Children aged 0-5 are reported to have an average of 4.1 hours of screen time daily (Bhatia, 2023).

These children grow up to be young individuals with an **immense dependency on their digital devices**, to prevent this from occurring one must confront how addicted humans are to digital devices, which can be a slippery slope to a digital addiction.

Digital addiction rarely comes to mind because our dependence on technology has become so normalised. However, it is crucial to start seeing this for what it is: an actual addiction that demands attention. Only once we acknowledge the problem can we begin to address it.

“A study found that 66.38% of adolescents aged 10-18 years are classified as internet addicts, with significant correlations to depression(Agarwal et al., 2020). Additionally, during the COVID-19 lockdown, 28.9% of adolescents reported feeling addicted to the internet, with 60.6% using electronic gadgets for over four hours daily(Bhave, 2023).”

In the current digital landscape, the accessibility of smartphones and the internet is increasing rapidly. The rise of services like Jio has brought internet access to remote parts of India that were previously cut off from such technology. While this has opened doors to countless opportunities, it has also created a surge in digital dependence, especially among the youth. Many young Indians now use their devices as emotional crutches, relying on digital platforms not only for entertainment, but also for emotional regulation.

For instance, artificial intelligence (AI) tools have become a popular means of "therapy," where users seek advice, validation, and emotional support. At first glance, this might seem like a practical solution to modern problems. However, confiding in AI instead of real human interactions can lead to further isolation, as individuals retreat from society and engage more with their devices instead of their close friends and family.

The issue is not limited to the younger generation. Even older people, who once criticised digital addiction, are now succumbing to it. The same generation that once warned younger people about the dangers of technology is now engrossed in it. *This sets a troubling example for younger generations.* When a child, whose brain is still developing and who is still forming their identity, sees their grandparents scrolling endlessly, they will naturally assume that this behaviour is normal. As a result, children will also begin doom scrolling for hours, which will not only damage their eyes due to screen strain but will also harm their brain development.

The conversation around digital addiction often centres around eye strain, but we rarely talk about how it affects the brain.

Our brains have become accustomed to the rapid dopamine hits that come from short-form content like TikTok or Instagram reels, where videos are typically 7 to 15 seconds long. This trains the **brain to crave these quick bursts of pleasure**, shortening our attention spans and

disrupting dopamine regulation. **Dopamine** is a neurotransmitter responsible for many critical functions, including the regulation of mood, pleasure, and even our circadian rhythm—the internal body clock that governs our sleep-wake cycle. When the brain is constantly flooded with dopamine from digital content, it becomes harder to experience pleasure from regular activities, leading to a kind of numbness or inability to focus.

One significant way digital addiction affects the brain is by disrupting sleep. Social media platforms are designed to be endlessly engaging, with no clear stopping point. You can scroll through content for hours without reaching the end, which leads to many people engaging with their phones right before bed.

The blue light emitted by smartphones interferes with the brain's production of melatonin, a hormone that helps regulate sleep. The brain is tricked into thinking it's still daytime, even late at night. Over time, this disruption to the sleep cycle can have severe effects on physical and mental health. When dopamine levels are consistently out of balance, not only does it affect sleep, but it also hinders the ability to focus on tasks, making daily functioning more challenging.

Digital addiction also often serves as an **escape from reality**. People may lose themselves in *video games*, spend hours swiping left and right on *dating apps*, or find themselves drawn into the world of *pornography*. These activities can seem like innocent distractions at first, but they can lead to more severe problems, including the development of **psychosis or other mental health disorders** in extreme cases. Each platform has its own mechanisms and algorithms to keep users coming back.

Video games often use reward systems, such as badges and levels, to encourage continued play. Dating apps offer the promise of love or the perfect match, even though the process of swiping endlessly often reduces real people to mere profiles on a screen. This gamification of human interaction has shifted our perception of love and relationships, making them feel transactional and superficial.

Pornography addiction, in particular, can have devastating effects on both the brain and relationships.

Much of the pornography available online is violent, male-centric, and objectifies women. This can distort a young person's perception of sex and relationships, damaging their body image and self-confidence. When someone becomes addicted to such content, it can also create a disconnect between real-life intimacy and the artificial pleasure derived from watching pornography, leading to strained relationships and emotional detachment.

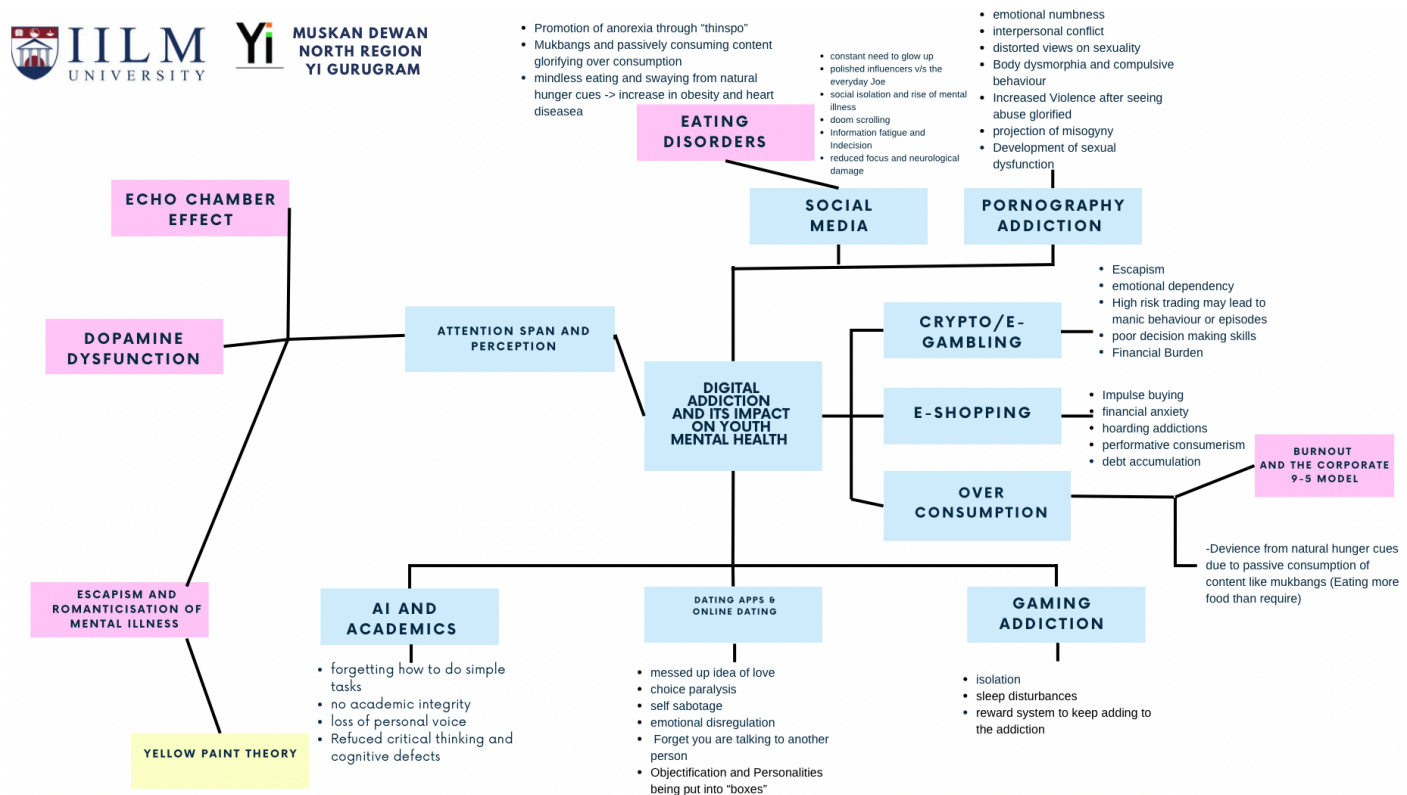
Several subsections of digital addiction are often overlooked. While most people are aware of social media addiction, there are other forms that deserve attention, such as online shopping addiction, online gaming addiction, and over-dependence on AI.

Each of these addictions has its unique impact on the brain and mental health, but they all share common themes of isolation, escapism, and the craving for dopamine-driven rewards.

The youth are especially vulnerable to the effects of digital addiction. Young people under the age of 25 are more impressionable because their **prefrontal cortex**—the part of the brain responsible for *decision-making, impulse control, and social behaviour*, is still developing. When social media and smartphones are introduced during adolescence, they become an integral part of a young person's identity and daily routine.

Many children refuse to go anywhere without their phones, and some even refuse to eat or sleep without them nearby. The phone becomes a source of comfort, much like a **pacifier**, but it also becomes a source of anxiety when it's not accessible. This kind of dependence on devices mirrors the kind of **withdrawal** a person might experience when separated from their drug of choice.

Impact on youth mental health and other Psychological Comorbidities



Upon closer inspection, the issue of digital addiction reveals several overlooked factors. Initially, when people think of digital addiction, they often focus solely on screen time or anxiety caused by social media or excessive scrolling. However, at its core, digital addiction is driven by a desire for *escapism*. Young people often use digital platforms to escape reality, which leads to the development of unhealthy coping mechanisms and emotional detachment.

Escapism and Avoidance: Many youths turn to digital platforms as an emotional crutch, using them to avoid dealing with real-life stressors, responsibilities, or even trauma. This reliance on digital escapism creates an unhealthy cycle. Emotional issues remain unresolved, leading to further detachment from reality, which can exacerbate mental health conditions.

If digital addiction crosses a certain threshold, it can lead to more serious mental health conditions, such as *psychotic disorders* or even *psychosis*, due to the high levels of derealization and depersonalization that occur when devices are used as tools for escapism. Withdrawal from excessive internet use can also trigger psychotic episodes. In one documented case, *a patient developed persecutory delusions after abruptly stopping a long-term gaming habit* (Paik et al., 2014). This highlights the severe risks that excessive digital dependency poses to mental health.

The Struggle to Break Free: One of the reasons digital addiction is so difficult to overcome is because the digital platforms are intentionally designed to keep users engaged. These platforms employ algorithms that create a feedback loop, designed to trigger dopamine-driven reward systems in the brain. This manipulation of dopamine pathways fosters compulsive behaviours, whether through gaming, social media, or online shopping apps. Each like, share, or level-up acts as a small reward that releases dopamine, which reinforces the behaviour and keeps the individual coming back for more.

As a society, we have transitioned from primarily visual content to an *audiovisual society*, spurred by the rise of platforms like Instagram and TikTok. This shift contributed to the shortening of attention spans, which first began with apps like *Vine*, a six-second video platform that took the world by storm. In India, the equivalent of Vine was *Dubsmash*, which led to a surge in short-form video content. While these apps provided entertainment, they inadvertently conditioned people to consume content in rapid, bite-sized pieces, leading to a collective decrease in attention span over time.

Recent studies suggest that the average attention span has significantly dropped in the last decade, being at an all time low of 7-15 seconds.

Shortened Attention Span: The overexposure to fast-paced digital content has resulted in an inability to focus for prolonged periods, which contributes to cognitive decline and the development of attention-deficit symptoms. Constantly switching between content disrupts our capacity to engage deeply with any single topic, diminishing our ability to concentrate or process

complex information. This leads to a pattern of always craving for **instant gratification** and the reduction of patience levels or **sensory overlord**.

Furthermore, *what* we consume is just as important as *how* we consume it. In India, the content generated by the audience often lacks emotional depth or connection to reality. Influencers produce content that caters to instant gratification, further deepening the emotional void many people experience. As a result, users find themselves in a cycle of **doom scrolling**—endlessly scrolling through negative or emotionally empty content in a desperate attempt to escape the emotional numbness they feel.

Doom Scrolling is defined as the act of continuously consuming negative news online, often despite its distressing nature. This behaviour has been exacerbated by the COVID-19 pandemic, leading individuals to seek information to cope with uncertainty, resulting in a cycle of anxiety and distress (Güme, 2024)(Wafa' et al., 2024).

Emotional Numbing: The constant engagement with digital content can severely reduce one's ability to process real-life emotions. This is known as *emotional numbing*, where the individual feels detached from their feelings and experiences a “flat affect,” or an inability to express or feel emotions.

Low self esteem: Seeing influencers on a daily basis can also result in *distorted identity formation*. Social media fosters a culture of comparison, where self-worth is measured in likes, followers, and external validation. Many youths are left feeling inadequate because their real lives don't match up to the curated, often misleading lives of the influencers they follow. This contributes to a negative self-image, damaging self-esteem, and distorting their sense of self-worth.

Cyberbullying and Online Harassment: Social media, while offering a platform for connection, also creates environments ripe for cyberbullying and harassment. Young people are especially vulnerable to online abuse, which can significantly impact their self-esteem, exacerbate anxiety, and lead to depression.

Social Isolation: Ironically, the more we connect digitally, the more we risk *social isolation*. Heavy reliance on digital interaction reduces face-to-face communication skills, which can lead to loneliness, difficulty in building real-life relationships, and ultimately, social withdrawal.

Pornography Addiction and Violent Behaviour: Another overlooked issue is the rise of *pornography addiction*, which not only alters sexual behaviour but also increases desensitisation to violence, particularly towards women. The constant exposure to sexually explicit or violent content can distort perceptions of intimacy, leading to unhealthy relationships and unrealistic expectations.

Co-occurring Addictions: Digital addiction often increases the risk of developing other types of addictions, such as substance abuse. The alteration in brain function due to digital addiction weakens impulse control, making individuals more susceptible to engaging in other addictive behaviours, compounding the overall mental health crisis.

Low cognitive and critical thinking skills, limited emotional regulation, and other mental health challenges often accompany digital addiction, exacerbating the problem and creating a vicious cycle of dependence, escapism, and emotional and cognitive decline.

Digital addiction has become a significant factor contributing to various mental health concerns among youth. Increased screen time, particularly through social media, is closely linked to heightened anxiety and depression. The "comparison culture" fostered by platforms like Instagram often leads to feelings of inadequacy, loneliness, and lower self-worth. This issue is further exacerbated by disruptions in dopamine pathways, which regulate mood and emotional balance. Additionally, youth increasingly turn to digital spaces such as gaming and online platforms for escapism. Over time, this can result in *emotional numbing, detachment from reality, and avoidance of real-life stressors*, thus perpetuating a cycle of **isolation** and digital dependency. Another growing concern is the shortened attention spans caused by fast-paced digital content. **This overexposure to constant digital stimuli not only impairs focus but also affects critical cognitive functions,** including memory and problem-solving abilities, leading to decreased academic performance. Moreover, social media's influence on self-identity and body image has distorted the sense of self, particularly among adolescents, as they become overly dependent on external validation through likes and comments, often resulting in body image dissatisfaction and mental health issues like anxiety and depression.

Furthermore, **cyberbullying** and online harassment have **surged due to the anonymity provided by digital platforms.** Victims of cyberbullying experience heightened feelings of helplessness and isolation, which significantly impact their mental well-being. **Exposure to pornography** is another problematic aspect of digital addiction, as **it distorts perceptions of relationships and sexuality, leading to emotional detachment and social isolation.** For many, this addiction contributes to a host of co-occurring mental health disorders. Additionally, gaming addiction, particularly in online multiplayer formats, has been associated with poor impulse control, aggressive behaviour, and social withdrawal, along with sleep disturbances and heightened anxiety. The rise in reliance on AI and technology for emotional support also presents challenges. As youth increasingly turn to AI tools for emotional engagement, their capacity for empathy and social connection deteriorates, fostering further detachment from human interaction and contributing to the growing issue of social isolation.

Survey data and Insights into the youth's perceptions

A survey was conducted with participants from both North and South India, capturing a diverse range of perspectives on digital addiction. Typically, youth are just seen as a target audience, reduced to mere numbers, but their input and insights into how they feel about digital addiction is crucial to developing solutions tailored to their needs. Their insights are key to creating scalable solutions that can effectively combat digital addiction.

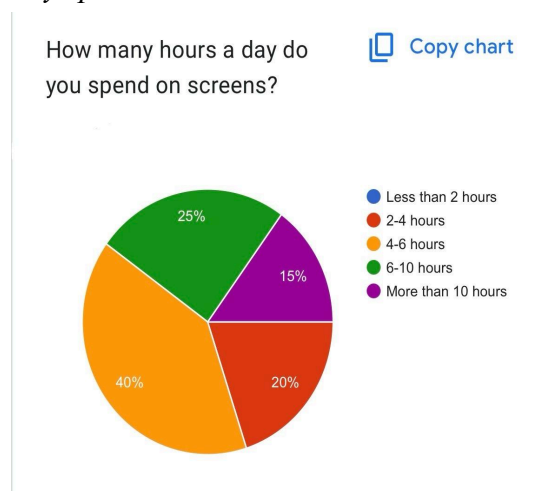
Today's generation has grown up surrounded by technology, making their feedback vital to helping younger generations avoid falling into similar traps. The current generation of toddlers is at an even higher risk, *growing up in a fully digitised world*.

Understanding the emotional and psychological impacts of digital addiction goes beyond simply collecting data and numbers. As *Maya Angelou* famously said, **“People will forget what you said, people will forget what you did, but people will never forget how you made them feel.”** This emphasises the importance of prioritising **emotional well-being** when addressing digital addiction, especially among youth across different regions of the country.

The intention of the survey was to give the youth a voice, here is how they answered the questions

Question one on the survey, asked, **how many hours do you spend on screens?**

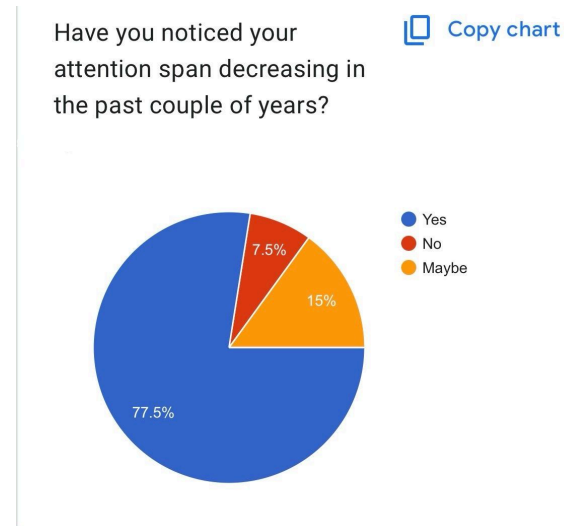
40% of people said they spent 4 to 6 hours 25% of people said they spent 6 to 10 hours 15% said they spent more than 10 hours on their screen.



Prolonged screen time usage can be linked with **cognitive function decline** where it can manifest as memory loss affecting your short term memory as well as making it harder for you to focus since there is a cognitive decline. It can also hamper your decision making skills and critical thinking.

Question two, Have you noticed your attention span decreasing in the past couple of years?

77.5% of the youth answered yes, and 15% answered, maybe



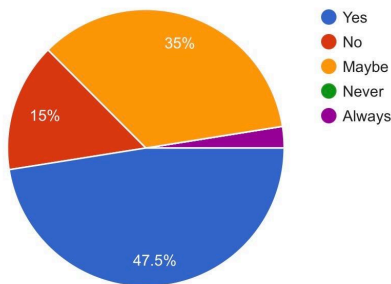
This directly addresses the **reduction in attention span** and the memory retention in youth cost by excess digital consumption. They have self-reported to feeling that their attention span has been decreasing since the past couple of years.

Question three, do you find it difficult to complete tasks without having the urge to check your phone or social media?

47.5% of the youth said yes, while 35% said maybe.

Do you find it difficult to complete tasks without having the urge to check your phone or social media?

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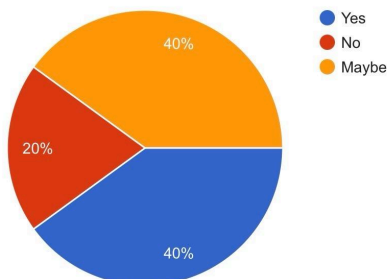
The youth has been trained to crave **instant gratification** in everything they do, constantly checking their phones and social media gives them a quick hit of dopamine. Since our communication is now mostly digital and instant, people want answers to communicative text messages instantly. The youth is losing patience due to this phenomena day by day.

Question four, do you think social media and pop culture is a central part of your humour and personality?

40% of the youth said yes and another 40% said maybe

Do you think social media and pop culture is a central part of your humor and personality?

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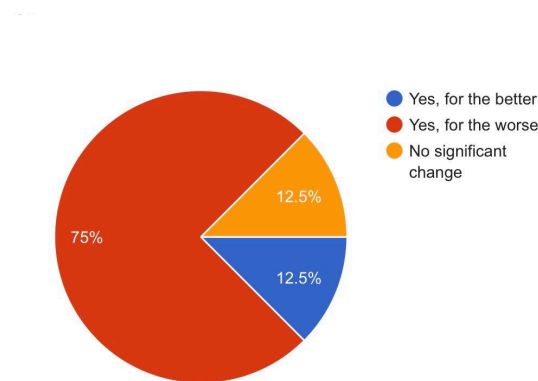
Due to the overwhelming amount of content available online, the youth finds themselves consuming content online most of the day which in turn impacts who they are, how they process

things, how they joke about things and their personality. This constant consumption of content can prove to be very overwhelming and can cause a **sensory overload**.

Question five, do you think online dating has changed the way people perceive love and relationships?

75% people said yes, online dating has change the way people perceive, love, and relationships for the worse

Do you believe online dating
has changed the way people
perceive relationships and
love?

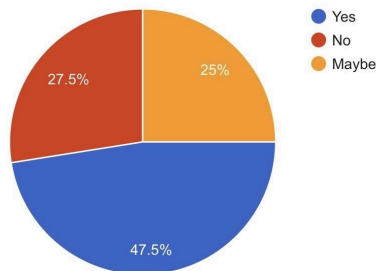


Online dating has definitely changed the digital landscape and how we perceive love, but the algorithm swiping left or right on people have reduced people to mere profiles and boxes apps like hinge, bumble, or tinder promise the idea of the “perfect match” and people keep swiping left or right and the validation from talking to other people gives them constant dopamine hits, which leads to another pattern of falling into the trap of **instant gratification**.

Question six, do you think social media acts as an echo chamber for reinforcing only the views you already agree with?

47.5% of the youth answered yes, while 25% answered, maybe

Do you think social media acts as an echo chamber, reinforcing only the views you already agree with?



Algorithms are very complex these days, especially pertaining to apps like Instagram. The reels section is an endless stream of content where the very precise algorithm only shows you what you are looking for or the content designed specifically to help you relate to it. Since relatability is very marketable in the social media sector, the algorithm will push something that the user already agrees with.

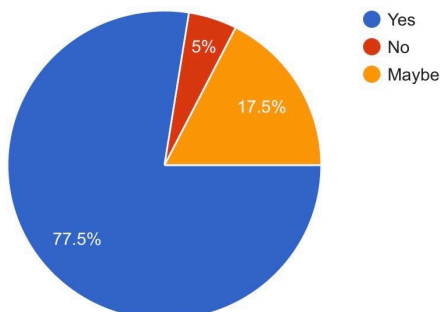
This reinforces the idea of not growing and social media acting as an echo chamber of the same beliefs, morals, and motives for everyone.

Which can prove to be very overwhelming, once someone is in the trap and causes **sensory overload and agitation**.

Question seven, do you think online dating makes it harder to form genuine human connections due to the influx of a number of choices?

77.5% of the youth answered yes, while 17.5 % answered maybe.

Do you think online dating makes it harder to form genuine emotional connections due to the influx number of choices?

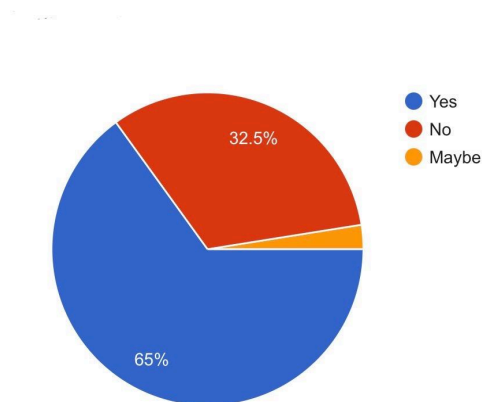


There is a phenomenon called “Choice paralysis” which can be caused due to the algorithms used in dating apps. People will start treating other human beings like options, resulting in a negative attitude towards other people, believing that there is a better person out there and swiping left or right constantly due to the app promising you the idea of “your perfect match”. This may result in frustration and anger. The anger often leads to a lot of **negative behavioural changes** towards other humans in extreme cases.

Question eight, have you ever bought something online impulsively that you later regretted?

65% of the youth answered, yes

Have you ever bought something online impulsively that you later regretted?



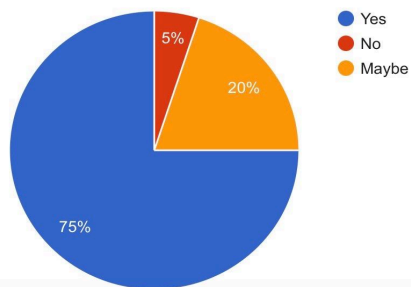
Many young Indians purchase items online impulsively due to the constant dopamine hits that it gives them. The idea of retail therapy has been made trendy online due to the dopamine increase people get after shopping online. Extreme online shopping can cause **dopamine dysregulation** in the brain of young Indians.

Question nine, do you think pornographic consumption leads to an increase in violence or aggression, especially towards women?

75% of the youth answered yes while 20% answered, maybe

Do you think pornography consumption leads to an increase in violence or aggression, especially toward women?

Source: IYF



Many young Indians online have restricted access to the Internet and can access pornography and often get addicted to watching pornography online. Studies show that exposure to pornography is linked to higher rates of unsafe sexual practices among youth (Ghule & Donta, 2011).

This can cause **behavioural issues** to occur and sense watching constant pornography also alters your image of sexuality of how you perceive yourself and other people can impair your interpersonal relationships as well as your dopamine regulation. There is a factor of **risk of co-occurring addictions** if any other substance is introduced into a person's life who is already battling upon addiction. Their brain is already used to the wavelength at which an addiction takes place, another addiction would be very easy for the sports to catch, and they are at a high risk factor for it alongside psychiatric comorbidities like depression or anxiety.

Existing solutions given by NGOs or the government

The growing concern about digital addiction among the youth of India has led many NGOs and government organisations to work towards solutions to combat this problem to come up with the solution for the youth. One would have to look at existing solutions and analyse them to

understand what worked and what did not work. These aspects will help shape the solutions provided for digital addiction in the future for the better.

These initiatives by the government and by many NGOs all over India are an acknowledgement that digital addiction is a crisis that needs to be combated with proper solutions and a good team working towards the betterment of the youth of India

In urban cities in sectors, we are seeing a boom and uprising in the number of detox centres. These detox centres will also take kids cases of digital addiction, particularly in children and families. Annual help them manage their screen time.

For instance, **Manasa group of hospitals in Karnataka** is trying to combat digital addiction specifically by offering structured programmes that would assist in reducing the reliance on technology instead of human intelligence.

NIMHANS or the national Institute of mental health and neurosciences in Bangalore has also made significant contributions via its service for healthy use of technology clinics these facilities provide counselling resources tailor to assist people manage their dependence on technology technology did scheduled also set up a helpline for parents to seek guidance on how to deal with the children's digital habits, especially since Jen alpha, digital habits are going out of control and they are overly dependent on their devices even to eat food. This helpline has proved to be helpful for a lot of parents.

There are numerous **campaigns run by students** and even corporate employees about the dangers of digital addiction. These campaigns are usually psycho educational in nature. And the campaigns may spread from urban cities to rural cities depending on the outreach of the connections.

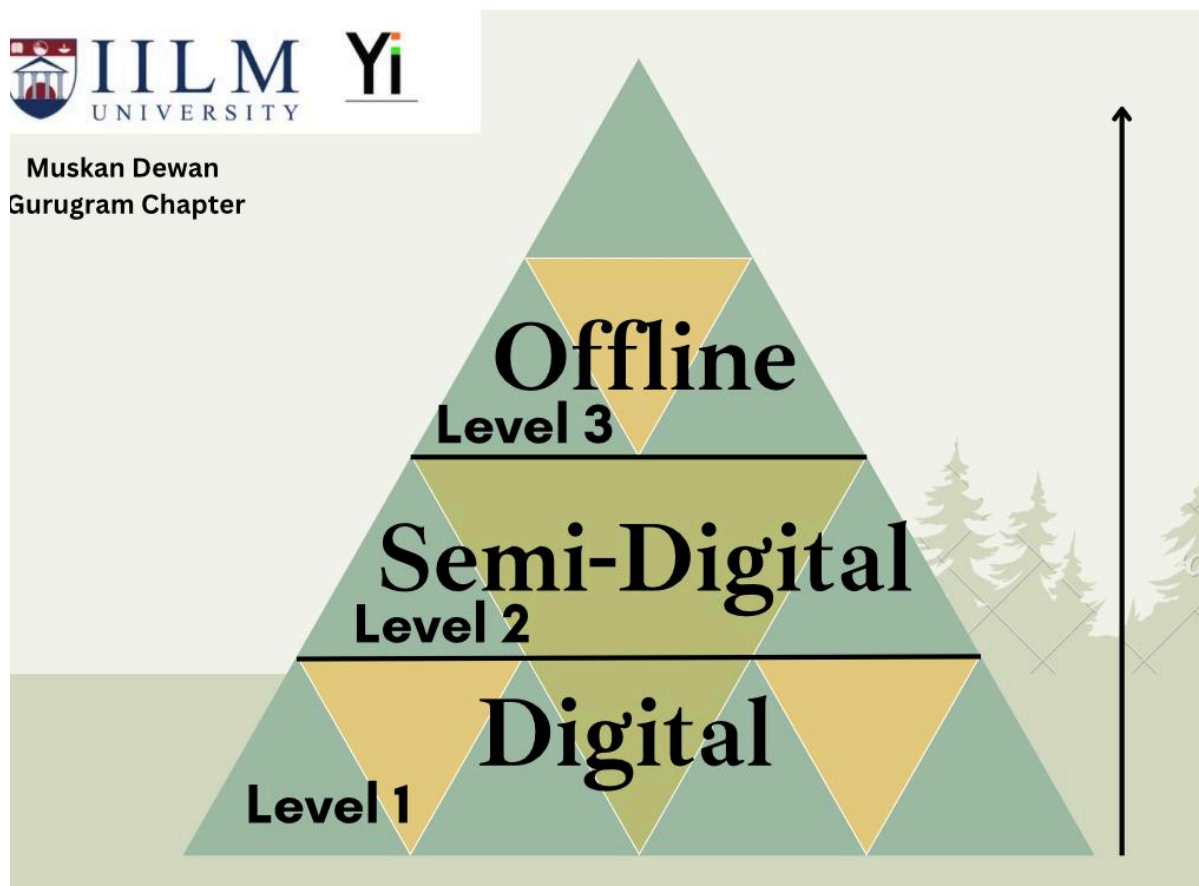
Many schools are starting to talk to the students about how digital addiction and digital dependence can be harmful. They are teaching students from a very young age. What **digital literacy is and what healthy technology use can look like** these educational initiatives will help students prevent potential risk associated with excessive screen time and will help them foster good and healthy habits with technology.

Many rural initiatives include digital literacy programmes where people are helping the rural communities understand digital literacy while also letting them know on how to use technology in a healthy way where it's not excessive. They are trying to help the people from getting dependent on technology as a way of escapism.

Suggested solutions: A three tier model to achieving a mindful india



Muskan Dewan
Gurugram Chapter

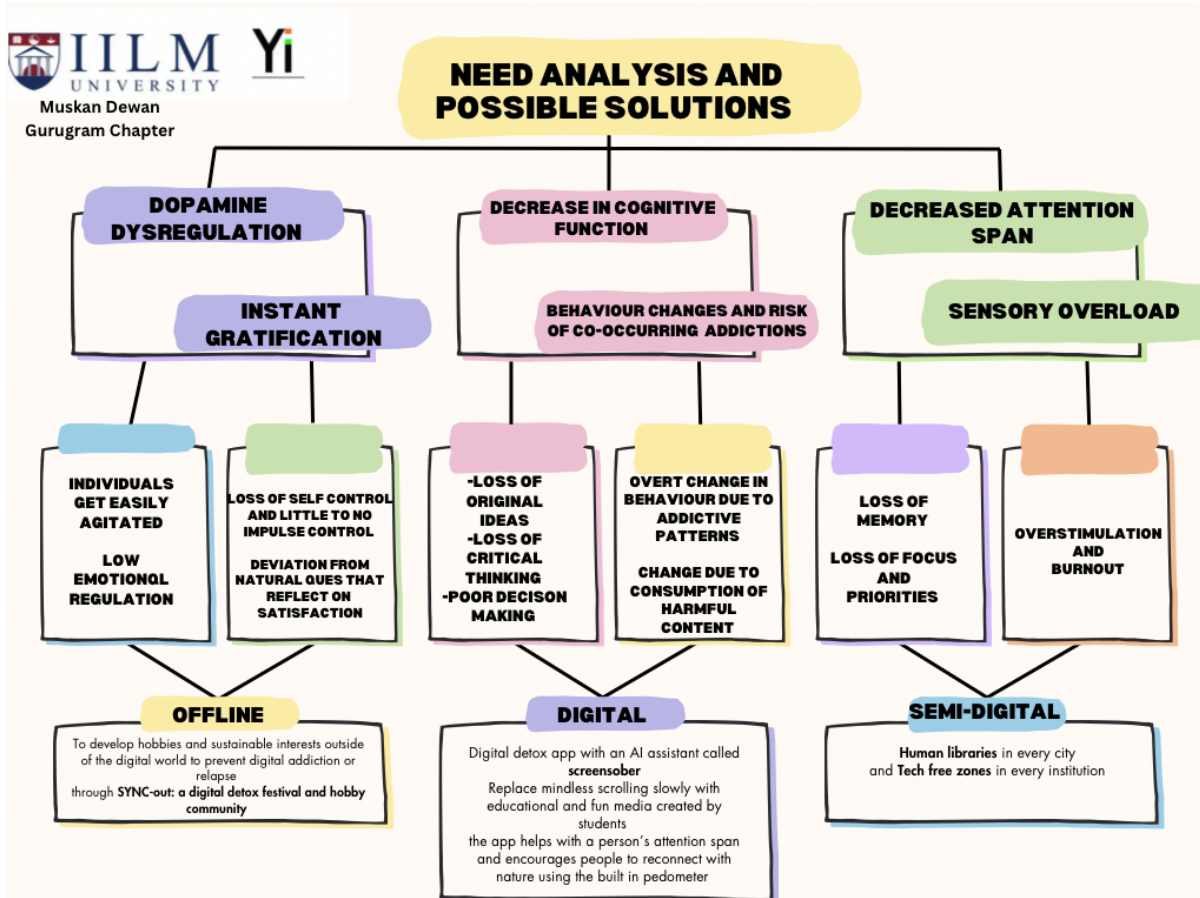


The suggested solutions encompass of three levels,

The survey showed that the youth of India feels that they have a decreased attention span than a few years ago. There are a few more underlying problems that came about after the survey.

These encompass of:

- Instant gratification
- Dopamine dysregulation
- Shorting of attention span
- Lower cognitive in critical thinking
- Behavioural changes
- A risk of co-addictions
- Instant gratification.



These problems were evaluated and understood what impact they have on a person's behaviour. **A need analysis was done in order to track down the best possible solutions for these problems that came out of the survey.**

These solutions come in three levels.

The first level is digital solutions: introducing an app called screen sober.

Screen Sober is an app designed to help people satisfy their craving for endless scrolling with content that is both educational and creative, made by students for students; youth for the youth. The concept is simple:

Just as a dietitian might suggest **replacing** unhealthy ingredients with **healthier alternatives** to enjoy good food in a nutritious way,

Screen Sober replaces mindless, never-ending streams of content (like Instagram Reels) with meaningful, inspiring content.

The app starts by showing users 15-second videos that are either educational or creatively stimulating. These videos are created by students and young Indians under the **Behind the screen** initiative, aim to inspire users to unlock their own creativity and learn from the life experiences and educational journeys of their peers.

Behind the screen would be a team of 50 + Young Indians who are striving for change, they will write, produce and film better and more intellectual content for the masses.

The content will be presented on ScreenSober exclusively, allowing the youth of India to explore their creative limits and learn essential skills like time management, team building and how to be your most creative self.

Students can make short or long form documentaries, challenging their limits and getting opportunities to grow as an individual. Their knowledge on topics they're well versed in can be spread throughout the country, inspiring others to grow and learn instead of spending hours scrolling online.

The website of Screensober will feature one documentary or form of content made by the youth every month, this will give students some incentive to work towards sharpening their skills and they will eventually be too involved in their hobbies to scroll mindlessly online.

(For example: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=H2SqL7Qxvfg&t=2s> is featured on the Screensober website as October 2024's documentary of the month)

Unlike social media feeds that never end, *Screen Sober's content stream is finite, and once the stream ends, users are prompted to put down their phones. An AI assistant checks in with the user daily, typically before bedtime, offering support in creating a personalised digital detox plan.*

As users become accustomed to the 15-second videos, the content duration gradually increases: first to 30 seconds, then to 60 seconds, and eventually up to 2-3 minutes. **This slow, steady increase helps users rebuild their attention span while passively learning from others.**

Students who have successfully overcome digital addiction will be encouraged to join the content creation team, sharing their experiences to help others as their peers once helped them.

The app also features challenges, such as a Digital Detox Competition. Equipped with a built-in pedometer, Screen Sober motivates users to take 10,000 steps a day and *spend time in nature*, encouraging real-world connections over digital distractions.

These competitions come with rewards, either monetary prizes or achievement badges that users can display on their profiles, adding extra motivation to their digital de-addiction journey.

Level two involves semi-digital spaces, including **human libraries** and **tech-free zones** in government and private schools, colleges, and workplaces. People would be encouraged to take 1–2 hours off daily to visit these spaces, where they can disconnect from devices and reconnect with themselves, nature, or friends. This is especially beneficial for those suffering from corporate burnout, as the current 9-to-5 model often leads to overwork, and exhaustion.

Tech-free zones would help individuals pause, reflect, and decide if they need a break or are ready to resume work.

Human libraries would allow people to share stories, struggles, and triumphs with others they might not typically interact with.

Originating in Copenhagen, Denmark, this concept could be adapted for both urban and rural India.

Sensitivity and leadership training for youth, especially in rural areas, would help facilitate these libraries and promote open conversations about digital addiction and mental health, topics that are often stigmatised in rural communities.

This initiative could also involve students from health and psychology fields, who can psycho-educate on issues like digital addiction, attention span, and dopamine regulation. Given the high rates of substance abuse in rural areas, addressing digital addiction early could prevent future risks.

Level three is the offline model, featuring a biannual digital detox festival called **Sync Out**.

This festival would bring together musicians, novelists, speakers, dancers, and other creative, successful individuals to share their journeys in a fun and inspiring way. The goal is to show young people what the real world offers outside the digital headspace they've created, giving them a glimpse of the careers they could pursue.

Organised by the youth for the youth, the festival would feature stories, music, and art centred around digital addiction, highlighting how artists themselves struggled with it but overcame it—providing a positive example and a ray of hope.

Sync Out would also host weekly hobby meetings.

Here an elected committee of youth would choose a hobby, such as art, philosophy, poetry, dance, skiing, hiking, basketball, etc.

Committee members would dedicate two hours each week to lead sessions for beginners or intermediate participants.

These sessions would create a space for people to focus on their hobbies, passions, or learning something new, all while connecting with like-minded individuals. For a while, participants can step away from the digital world and live in the moment.

This model helps build a community around shared interests, offering a solution to the social isolation caused by digital addiction.

YUVA INVOLVEMENT

The youth will be leading the initiatives in the digital level one solution. They will create and monitor all the content for the app, with guidance from a mentor. Students from journalism can collaborate with those in psychology and law to discuss creative yet educational career prospects or share fun facts from their fields.

This will help users struggling with digital addiction feel a sense of scrolling, while passively gaining knowledge and gradually improving their attention span. Similar to Hank Green's Crash Course app, it's a platform of knowledge, with additional steps toward digital detox and an AI assistant.

The youth will also organise the Sync Out events and hobby courses. Each committee member will take on a hobby they are passionate about

such as:

poetry, philosophy, dance, hiking, music, painting, or journaling, and dedicate two hours a week to host meetings. These hobby sessions will offer people the chance to step out of the digital headspace and meet others with similar interests. Even those trying something new to ease their digital detox journey will be welcome.

Sync Out will hold a biannual Digital Detox Fest, where students partner with musicians, artists, novelists, and other notable figures to discuss digital addiction in a fun and enlightening way.

A Digital Deaddiction Cell (EC) of CII YUVA could also be introduced at the school level, allowing students to build early connections in their fields early on. This EC could launch a Digital Addiction and Detox Wing, hosting panel discussions and events around the topic.

Young adults pursuing psychology master's degrees will take on pro bono cases in rural areas, organising human libraries and engaging with communities to spread awareness about digital addiction.

This is critical as rural areas make up over half of India's population. These young professionals will help educate people about the dangers of digital addiction and related issues. Other students involved in CII YUVA, will partner with children to help their parents understand how digital

addiction is a growing concern for Generation Alpha and will continue to worsen unless addressed now.

The youth are central to these initiatives, and the three levels aim to achieve a digitally detoxed India.

Though the goal will take time, these plans, created by the youth for the youth, have the potential to create a lasting impact.

Future generations may thank us for protecting their minds and attention spans, giving them a world with greater potential than we can currently imagine.

If more minds join and collaborate, the ideas will grow beyond what we envisioned, leaving an impact that could last for generations.

SOLUTION MODEL

Name: Screensober

Aim: To reduce screen time, increase attention span, make the youth more mindful, give them a platform for creativity (mindful media initiative, creative and learning based content made by the youth for the youth: <https://youtu.be/Un4Q7d9zHKA?si=O3WBTraAWD8tJHHD>)

AI powered assistant to help make digital detox plans tailored for individuals with different needs

Scalability: Can be spread across the country with a simple click, every state can have its own team where they create culturally accurate content representing their state and their collective struggles with digital addiction)

Realistic timeline of change: 4-6 months for individuals to reduce their screen time and increase their attention span.

One year for people to collectively start giving importance to knowledgeable and creative content online.

Website for screensober: <https://muskandewan3.wixsite.com/syncout>

Scan to get the mobile website for screensober:



After a year of screensober's success, the youth will start planning a biannual digital detox festival and running hobby clubs so that people stay away from devices and engage with different creative and challenging pursuits.

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THE END